

There was a man who said this. He had two sons and a daughter. All very erudite and genteel. And no, they did not fight at all after the man passed away after a long and meaningful life. But it was a nightmare for the kids, sorting his estate out – just getting the documentation done to transfer assets took time and effort. Things become even tougher if the kids are not in India any more. You may have really great kids, and they may not fight over the assets, but it is just unkind not to leave a road map for them.

Why make a will, I have nominations in place

A common enough pushback to a will. But did you know that a nomination does not mean that the nominees get the assets? Look at the nominee as a caretaker of the asset, somebody to whom the money flows to for safekeeping till the legal heirs can stake a claim. In your head the nominee and the legal heir is the same person, but in the eyes of the law, the two could be different.

How to make a will

You'll have to map the current assets – bank deposits, bonds, mutual funds, stocks, properties, gold, jewellery, vehicles, assets created overseas, books, art, wine and whatever you want to bequeath to your heirs. It's a good idea to make an itemized list of things: where they are kept and where the papers that establish the claim are kept.

It's always a good idea to put down details like passwords to online bank accounts in a password-protected dynamic Excel sheet. Put down in writing the location of property papers and locker keys.

Once the details are done, indicate who should get what. For example, if you have two flats and want to leave one to each kid, do specify which one goes to whom. If there is jewellery, mention who gets what. Maybe take pictures and specify who gets what. Don't forget to include ownership of social media accounts, email addresses, intellectual property rights.

The myth of a big happy family gets destroyed at some point in most people's lives. So do your kids and surviving spouse a favour and pin down